high-altitude area. I also got my first view of Nathu La, on the border between China and India. I have been to Nathu La many times since that first visit, in almost every rank from Captain to General. Soon enough the handing over was completed and we were off to Bikaner by the middle of August, but not before some last-minute excitement. 2 SIKH LI was also part of the Division and deployed on the border. A large patrol of this unit comprising several officers, JCOs and men got disoriented in poor weather and wandered across to the Chinese side, where they were apprehended. All the personnel were repatriated after a few days, no harm done except for a few bruised egos, but it was a great embarrassment to all and created quite a furore.

Bikaner

At Bikaner, we were initially part of 8 (Independent) Infantry Brigade (Indep Bde), directly under the Corps. As part of some re-balancing, the Battalion was then placed under 322 Infantry Brigade, on the Order of Battle (ORBAT) of 12 Infantry Division (Inf Div). Shortly thereafter, 24 Inf Div was raised so we reverted to 8 Infantry Brigade but now under 24 Infantry Division. Rajat Das, whose father had been the Commander in Sikkim was the first General Officer Commanding (GOC) of this Division, so in a sense, we were back under him. All through this, while we remained at Bikaner, our operational role and Area of Responsibility (AOR) kept changing. As part of the Indep Bde, we were the Corps reserve; in 12 Inf Div, holding defences at Tanot in Western Rajasthan. In 24 Inf Div, we reverted to the reserve role, which could entail both offensive and defensive tasks. As a result, in one tenure, the Battalion gained rich experience in operations from the 'green' semi-desert area in the North around Sri Ganganagar/

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